



STEPPE

Master Case for Support

The reusable grant narrative

REDMOND • CENTRAL OREGON • EST. 2026

v1.2 • 2026-07-09

A member-governed Oregon public benefit nonprofit.

Internal note • 2026-07-09. Working draft, converted from Word to Markdown and rebranded to Steppe. Facts to rely on: the fiscal sponsor is **Ignite Empowerment Foundation**, a Central Oregon 501(c)(3) (EIN 99-3872440), with the sponsorship agreement pending signature. Director Brandon Weimer is the spouse of the foundation's founder, so Steppe and the foundation handle their arrangement as a disclosed related party (see docs/governance/). Dues are **\$4 a month**. The founding board is Chism, Cobb, and Weimer, with a fourth independent director planned. Before sending this to a funder, apply the open items in docs/funding/funder-pack-corrections-v1.md (grant-ask sizing, board-independence wording, and the 2026 pipeline dates).

STEPPE

Master Case for Support — v1.2

June 2026 • The reusable grant narrative — every application draws from this document

This is the source document for all funding requests. Sections are written to be lifted whole into grant portals, letters, and conversations — consistent language, consistent numbers, consistent story. Bracketed fields are completed per application.

01 --- The Case in One Paragraph

Steppe is community-owned digital infrastructure for the towns of Central Oregon — a verified, ad-free, member-governed platform where neighbors share events, needs, and decisions. It launches in Redmond in late 2026, built and governed to stay member-owned, dues-funded, and accountable to the people it serves. Dues of \$4 a month fund its core operations forever; grant support funds what dues alone cannot cover: bilingual access, accessibility, youth workforce development, and expansion to the rural towns that need it most.

02 --- The Need

Central Oregon's communities have no shared information infrastructure they own or trust. The regional newspaper has retrenched. National platforms fill the vacuum badly: feeds engineered for outrage, no connection to place, no accountability to residents, and business models that treat communities as inventory. Word of mouth remains the most trusted local channel — and it cannot scale.

The cost lands hardest outside Bend. Redmond, Sisters, La Pine, Madras, Prineville, Terrebonne, and Culver — communities of trades, agriculture, and working families — have the least local coverage and the least digital infrastructure built for them. Roughly one in three Madras residents speaks Spanish at home, and almost nothing in the region's civic information layer does. When a wildfire approaches, when a school board decides, when a neighbor needs firewood or has it to give, there is no trusted, verified place where that information moves.

This is not a content problem; it is an ownership problem. Every previous platform serving the region answers to advertisers or distant shareholders. The infrastructure failed because of who owned it — so the fix has to start there.

03 --- The Solution

Steppe is a member-governed Oregon nonprofit operating a community platform that residents verify into, pay \$4 a month for, and govern by vote. The structure is the innovation:

- **Owned by no one, governed by members** — an Oregon public benefit nonprofit with statutory voting members; no shares, no exit, a dissolution clause routing assets to aligned local charities. The commitments — no advertising ever, member-owned data, community control — are written into the articles of incorporation
- **Verified and local** — membership requires proof of residency through multiple pathways with human review; the platform deletes verification documents the moment a decision is made
- **Calm to use** — feeds ordered chronologically by time and proximity, so the platform surfaces what is recent and nearby
- **Democratic in fact** — secret-ballot member votes with tenure weighting and quorum rules, enforced in the database itself; quarterly public transparency reports; moderation with due process and appeal
- **Already built** — the platform is complete and security-audited as of June 2026 — verification, neighborhood-scoped events, governance voting, moderation, Spanish localization, accessibility, and mobile — with 35 Redmond neighborhoods mapped. Grant support does not fund a hope; it finishes and extends a working system

The design draws on established scholarship in commons governance, systems thinking, and political economy — the platform’s governance is audited against the eight design principles that distinguish community resources that endure from those that collapse, and its structure is built against the documented decay pattern of advertising-funded platforms. A full sources statement is available on request.

04 --- Who We Serve

- **Now** — Redmond, Oregon (~36,000 residents, 35 mapped neighborhoods) — launch late 2026, with Redmond Compass as community partner and two of three founding board members rooted in Redmond
- **Next** — the rural towns of Central Oregon — Sisters, La Pine, Madras, Prineville, Terrebonne, Culver — joining by petition and community vote, with full Spanish-language access
- **Always** — capped at twelve communities by charter. Steppe is built to serve a place deeply, not to scale; the cap is a structural promise that growth will never outrun governance
- **Beneath the platform** — Steppe Connect extends the mission to access itself: rural connectivity pilots with community and cooperative partners, makerspace-built public access devices, and — on the long horizon, at the Tribes’ invitation — a tribal digital-sovereignty program built on complete tribal ownership of platform, infrastructure, data, and governance

05 --- What Funding Builds

Member dues fund core operations permanently — hosting, administration, and basic upkeep are never grant-dependent. Grants fund the layers that make the platform genuinely public infrastructure:

Package A --- Launch Capacity (\$12,500, one year)

Completes the gap between a working platform and a publicly trustworthy one before the late-2026 launch.

Line Item	Amount
Spanish localization — professional native-speaker review of the full platform dictionary	\$2,000
Accessibility & contrast audit across the final visual design	\$1,500
Volunteer moderator recruitment & training (minimum three, Redmond-calibrated)	\$1,000
Legal — plain-language Terms review & nonprofit filings	\$3,000
Directors & officers insurance (year one)	\$1,500
Hosting & infrastructure (year one)	\$1,500
Bilingual community outreach materials	\$1,000
Fiscal sponsorship administration (8%)	\$1,000
Total	\$12,500

Package B — Civic Infrastructure for Rural Central Oregon (\$48,000, two years)

The flagship program: deepening Redmond and carrying the platform to the rural towns that need it most, with the community doing the carrying.

Year One	\$24,000
Part-time community coordinator (Redmond-based) — cohort support, moderation program, neighborhood outreach	\$12,000
Listening sessions across rural towns — Sisters, La Pine, Madras, Prineville, Terrebonne, Culver	\$3,000
Spanish localization & accessibility maintenance	\$3,500
Public transparency reporting (quarterly, bilingual)	\$2,000
Bilingual outreach & materials	\$1,500
Administration	\$2,000
Year Two	\$24,000
Community coordinator (continued)	\$10,000
Paid student internship pilot — two Central Oregon students (tech & community tracks), above minimum wage, public showcase	\$8,000
Localization & accessibility maintenance	\$3,000
Internship showcase & program evaluation	\$1,500
Administration	\$1,500
Two-Year Total	\$48,000

Package C — Organizational Capacity (\$8,000–\$12,000, technical assistance)

For capacity-focused funders: nonprofit-formation counsel, fundraising-systems setup, board development, and financial-controls consulting — strengthening a young organization’s spine so program dollars land well. Scoped to the funder’s TA guidelines.

Package D — Connect: Rural Access Pilot (\$15,000–\$25,000, one year, 2028 horizon)

For infrastructure- and access-focused funders, once the platform’s first town is saturated: public access points at libraries and community centers in one rural partner town — single-board-computer kits in enclosures designed and fabricated by Central Oregon students through our college and makerspace partnerships, deployed with a local cooperative partner, maintained through our paid internship program, and reported publicly like everything else we do. Scope and budget are finalized with the deployment partner; the package exists now so infrastructure funders can see where the mission goes.

06 --- Outcomes & How We Measure

- **Membership & reach** — verified members (targets: 100 by end of 2026; 200 — roughly 0.5% of Redmond — by mid-2027); neighborhoods active; bilingual usage rates

- **Civic participation** — governance votes held and turnout; community proposals submitted; events posted and attended
- **Trust & fairness** — appeal rate vs. quiet-exit rate (our earliest health signal); moderation actions and outcomes published quarterly; transparency reports delivered on schedule
- **Rural & bilingual access** — listening sessions completed per town; Spanish-language adoption in Madras-area outreach; verification accommodation cases resolved (PO box, non-standard documents)
- **Youth workforce (year two)** — interns hired and paid; showcase delivered; post-internship placement

Every measure above is already instrumented in the platform's health dashboard or transparency-report pipeline — reporting to funders uses the same numbers the public sees, which is the point.

07 --- Organizational Credibility

- **Governance** — a published Governance Charter; member voting enforced at the database layer with secret ballots and an unforgeable audit log; a full security audit completed before launch
- **Board** — three founding directors — two rooted in Redmond civic and business life (the founder of Redmond Compass; the owner of Herringbone Books) — majority-independent, with a conflict-of-interest policy from the first meeting and member-elected seats mandated within 24 months
- **Leadership** — founding Executive Director [GREG CHISM — one-line bio: university faculty member and civic-technology builder], serving under a board-set, publicly disclosed, deliberately below-market compensation framework
- **Partnership** — Redmond Compass as launch partner for community information and the local exchange; developing partnerships with Connect Central Oregon (regional capacity and volunteer network), the Oregon Broadband Equity Coalition (statewide digital-equity network), and the outward-facing units of OSU-Cascades and COCC for internships, makerspace fabrication, and the regional data-literacy bridge
- **Status** — Oregon public benefit nonprofit corporation (formed 2026); federal tax-exemption application filed [DATE]; fiscally sponsored by [SPONSOR NAME, EIN] pending determination; registered with the Oregon DOJ Charitable Activities Section

08 --- Financial Model & Sustainability

Steppe is built so that no funder — public or private — ever becomes a dependency. Member dues of \$4 a month fund core operations permanently: at 500 members, operations are covered; at 1,000, comfortably. Grant funding is additive by rule — it builds capacity and expansion, never keeps the lights on. No single funder may exceed 30% of annual revenue, no funding is accepted whose conditions touch the founding commitments, and every grant and its conditions are published in the quarterly transparency report. Surplus beyond operations flows to local charities chosen each year by ranked-choice member vote. Funders are not asked to sustain Steppe; they are asked to extend what a self-sustaining commons can reach.

09 --- Boilerplate (lift as needed)

One sentence

Steppe is a community-owned, ad-free, member-governed digital platform for the towns of Central Oregon, launching in Redmond in 2026.

Short (≈60 words)

Steppe is community-owned digital infrastructure for Central Oregon: a verified, ad-free platform where neighbors share events, needs, and decisions — governed by member vote, funded by \$4-a-month dues, and structured as an Oregon nonprofit that can never be sold or run advertising. It launches in Redmond in late 2026 and is capped by charter at twelve communities.

Medium (≈120 words)

Steppe is a member-governed Oregon nonprofit building community-owned digital infrastructure for the towns of Central Oregon. Residents verify their local address, pay \$4 a month, and receive a calm, chronological platform for neighborhood events, mutual exchange, and community decisions — with secret-ballot member voting, due-process moderation, full Spanish-language access, and quarterly public transparency reports. Its founding commitments — no advertising ever, member-owned data, community control — are written into its articles of incorporation, and surplus revenue flows to local charities chosen by member vote. The platform is built and security-audited, launches in Redmond in late 2026 with Redmond Compass as community partner, and expands only by community petition and vote, capped at twelve towns.

STEPPE · Master Case for Support v1.2 · June 2026